

APRIL 1-15, 1980

enemy attack after 26/11 ("Combat Unready", February 1). Procurement, upgradation and modernisation of defence equipment do not seem to form key areas of the Defence Ministry. Given the increase in border incursions, terrorist attacks in Kashmir and an unpredictable neighbour in China, India needs an able and responsive defence minister, but the position is occupied by a person high in party loyalty and low on strategic thinking. **Y.G. CHOUKSEY, Pune**

The story had a poignant photograph of an infantry man running into a battle zone wearing woollen gloves. Nothing wrong with the glove, but probably this illustrates best how our bureaucrats function. Even a proper glove (which should be a part of standard uniform for all high altitude warfare) is best provided by the soldier's family than the army. Forget the US and Chinese armies, even the Pakistani and Bangladeshi infantry men are better dressed than our soldiers. If this is the condition of standard uniforms, how can we expect the World War II vintage grenades to be upgraded?

INDRANIL SARKAR,
Kolkata

Victim of Politics

What is said about the alleged bankrupt policies of

the Punjab Government is true for other states ("Plain Broke", February 1). The taxpayers' hard-earned money is spent like freebies on gimmick schemes announced to catch the voters' attention. The situation can improve only if experts, rather than political rulers, become decision makers.

MADHU AGRAWAL, Delhi

Punjab Finance Minister



“Indian mobile phone brands can easily outgrow Chinese ones as they are adding the latest features in their products. Everyone wants a big chunk of one of the fastest growing markets in India.”

V.K. TANGRI, Dehradun

Manpreet Singh Badal is a genuine person, but his hands are tied due to political compulsions. The seeds of this dismal scenario in Punjab were sown way back in late 1970s when the Congress ignited the flames of terrorism and the downward slide of one of the most prosperous states started.

A.K. SHARMA,
Chandigarh

Power Failure

Congressmen who had failed as chief ministers in states and in the Union Cabinet (except for M.K. Narayanan as statesman) are being appointed as ministers at the Centre or governors ("The Raj Calculus", February 1). Shivraj Patil was removed as home minister for failing to contain a number of terrorist attacks. Vilasrao Deshmukh was replaced

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by Ashok Chavan for the same reason after 26/11. The same Deshmukh is now minister for heavy industries at the Centre. So what message does it send? If you want plum posts, join the Congress. You need not be efficient. You must be an expert only in the art of sycophancy or close to the Gandhi family. **A. SRIKANTALAH,**
Bangalore

Pressure All Round

"A government that governs" — the slogan, after carrying Mrs Gandhi through her comeback trail, disappeared from the scene altogether. This successful vote-catching slogan would have died unsung if the Marxists of Bengal had not resurrected it last fortnight. After staying in power for 33 months, the Left Front in West Bengal seems bitten by the conscience bug. Its leaders are publicly expressing their disappointment over the gap between pledges and achievement. The chief minister, Jyoti Basu, is openly reprimanding comradely clerks in government offices for not coming to office on time. Promode Dasgupta, the cigar-puffing chairman of the Left Front Committee, is pulling up "backward ministers" at closed-door sessions in a style reminiscent of Victorian public schools. Their common motto today—"A government must govern." For senior leaders of the Front, the task has a grave note of urgency. They are more or less convinced that Mrs Gandhi and her Congress (I) will soon be rallying all its strength to break the myth of the Leftist invincibility. **by Sumit Mitra**



JYOTI BASU

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